POST-STRUCTURALISM IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

From the discussions in the preceding sections especially the sections on Liberalism, and Realism and Neo-Realism one thing can be understood clearly that what we take to be real, timeless and universal in the field of IR is the result of imposition of a form of order. The dominant interpretations of the 'world' which have been established traditionally talks of states and their policy-makers pursuing their national interests. Therefore, the way the discipline of IR perceives the world makes it evident that the discipline is characterized by different paradigms competing in 'great debates'.

Post-structuralism engages itself with these issues of representation, the relationship of power and knowledge and the politics of identity to the production and understanding of global politics. One should not perceive Post-structuralism as a new set of paradigm in IR. Rather it is critical attitude, approach, or ethos that calls attention to the importance of representation, the relationship of power and knowledge and the politics of identity in an understanding of global affairs.

The critical attitude of Post-structuralism can be traced in the writings of Michael Foucault[§§]. Post-structuralism as an approach emerged in the field of IR in the 1980s. The prominent scholars who introduced Post-structuralism are Richard Ashley, James Der Derian, Michael and Shapiro, David Campbell and R.B.J. Walker to name a few. Post-structuralism mainly focusses on the following points which may be summarized as:

1. Articulate the meta-theoretical[¶¶] critique of the dominant paradigms like the realist theories of IR.
2. Connects IR to its inter-disciplinary context by introducing new sources of theory.
3. Concerned about how the relations of inside and outside were mutually constructed.
4. Focusses on identity, subjectivism and powers.
5. Shiftes analysis from assumptions about pre-given subjects to the problematic of subjectivity and its political enactment.
6. Employs a methodological precepts of interpretation,